A Visionary Force Reengineering India's Social Challenges into Pathways of Progress

Dr. Payal Bansal Kanodia



Power, in the twenty-first century, is no longer defined solely by market capitalisation or boardroom influence. It is measured by the ability to move societies forward, build institutions that outlast individuals, and create opportunities where none previously existed. **Dr. Payal Bansal Kanodia exemplifies this new definition of leadership.** As Promoter of M3M India and Chairperson & Trustee of M3M Foundation, she has quietly built one of India's fastest-growing philanthropic ecosystems one that has already touched more than 4.9 million lives across 21 states 4 union territories and 1300 +Villages. Her work sits at the convergence of responsible enterprise, climate resilience, women's economic participation, child development, and nation-building, positioning her among a new generation of Indian women leaders who are redefining influence through measurable impact. **What distinguishes Dr. Kanodia is that she does not view philanthropy as charity. She views it as institution building.** An MBBS graduate with advanced studies in Family Business Management from ISB Hyderabad, Entrepreneurship at Harvard Business School, and a Doctorate in International Relations and Diplomacy, she brings an uncommon blend of scientific thinking, entrepreneurial vision and public leadership to every initiative she leads. That multidisciplinary outlook has enabled her to design programmes that are not episodic acts of giving, but scalable systems capable of solving structural social challenges. Her philosophy is simple yet transformative: economic opportunity is the foundation of human dignity. That philosophy has shaped the evolution of M3M Foundation into a platform where education, livelihood, healthcare, environmental stewardship, sports, and women's leadership are interconnected pillars of inclusive development. **Perhaps nowhere is her impact more visible than in women's empowerment.** Under her leadership, M3M Foundation has built pathways that enable women to transition from dependency to entrepreneurship and financial independence. Through livelihood creation, enterprise development, skilling, mentorship and grassroots leadership programmes spanning rural India from the Ghats of Varanasi to the Nilgiris, Ladakh and Spiti Dr. Kanodia is working towards an ambitious vision of empowering one million women through entrepreneurship and livelihoods. During her tenure as Chairperson of FICCI YFLO Delhi in 2024-2025, her entrepreneurship and skilling initiatives reached over one million women, creating one of the largest women-led outreach movements undertaken by the organisation.

For Dr. Kanodia, empowering women is not merely a social objective; it is one of India's greatest economic opportunities. The same belief underpins Kaushal Sambal, M3M Foundation's flagship skill development programme. Across 19 iMPower Academies in seven states, the initiative has trained over 12,000 youth, achieving a remarkable 76 percent placement rate while extending its reach to more than 353 villages. Through complementary enterprise initiatives, 3,000 young people have been supported in creating livelihoods, with nearly 72 percent establishing entrepreneurial or income-generating ventures. Each skilled youth represents more than employment—they represent stronger families, more resilient communities, and a more productive Indian economy. **Education remains another defining pillar of her leadership.** Through M3M Foundation's education initiatives and the iMPower programme, Dr. Kanodia has championed access to quality education, digital inclusion and foundational learning for children from underserved communities. The Foundation has impacted impacted 1M children, awarded 2474 scholarships, supported 28,000 students through educational infrastructure, distributed 446 digital learning devices, and strengthened foundational literacy and numeracy for 8.16 Lakh children. Simultaneously, its migrant education programme has connected thousands of vulnerable families with learning opportunities while enabling children to transition into mainstream schooling. **If education builds futures, climate action protects them.** Long before environmental sustainability became a corporate imperative, Dr. Kanodia positioned conservation as a core pillar of M3M Foundation's development agenda. Through Sankalp and VanJeevan, she has emerged as one of corporate India's strongest advocates for community-led climate action. Under her leadership, the Foundation has planted over 6.5 lakh trees, established 100+ Sankalp Vatikas, rejuvenated many water bodies, and helped create ecological assets with a cumulative water-holding capacity exceeding 240 million litres. Her environmental interventions extend well beyond plantation drives. Solar-powered water systems